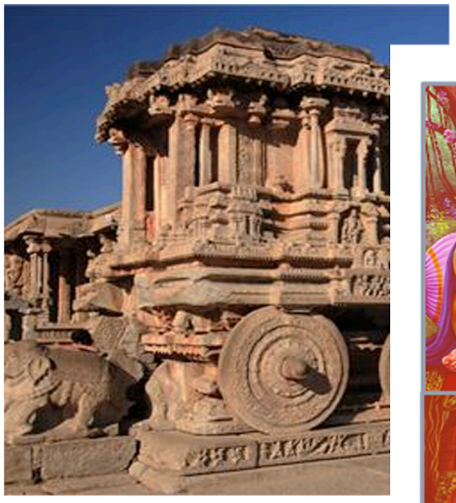
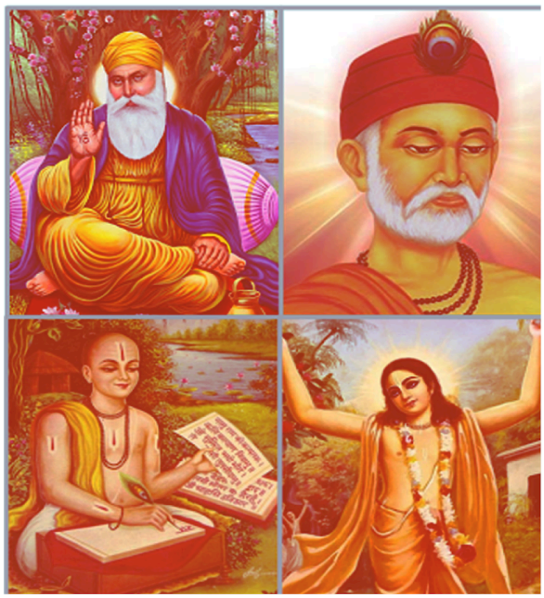
testbook PASS PRO MAX

General Knowledge
Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

AKBAR





AKBAR
(1542 to 1605 A.D.)

EARLY LIFE

- Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar was the third Mughal Emperor, succeeding his father Humayun.
- He was born in Umerkot (modern-day Pakistan).

REIGN

- Akbar ascended the throne in 1556 at the **age of 13** after Humayun's death.
- During his early years, his rule was managed by **Bairam Khan**, his regent, who helped secure his authority, especially after defeating Hemu in the Second Battle of Panipat (1556).

AKBAR'S NAVRATNAS (NINE GEMS)

S.No	Nava Ratnas	Description
1	Raja Todar Mal	The finance minister who introduced standard weights and measures; was awarded the title Diwan-i-Ashraf.
2	Abul Fazel	Historian and author of Akbarnama; served as a key advisor in Akbar's court.
3	Faizi	Persian poet and brother of Abul Fazel; oversaw the Persian translation of the Mahabharata.
4	Fakir Aziao Din	Sufi advisor and one of Akbar's chief spiritual counselors; practiced Sufi music.

5	Tansen	Renowned musician and poet; was awarded the title "Mian" by Akbar for his musical brilliance.
6	Abdul Rahim Khan-i-Khanan	Poet and son of Bairam Khan; translated Baburnama into Persian.
7	Raja Man Singh	Trusted general of Akbar and brother of Akbar's wife Jodhabai.
8	Mirza Aziz Koka	Foster brother of Akbar; also known as Khan-i-Azam.
9	Raja Birbal (Mahesh Das)	Wit and close confidant of Akbar; given the title of Raja and Birbal by Akbar.

IMPERIAL EXPANSION

- Akbar empire extended from Afghanistan in the northwest to Bengal in the east, and as far south as Gujarat and parts of the Deccan.

MAJOR BATTLES FOUGHT

Second Battle of Panipat (1556):

Akbar, still a teenager, faced the challenge of Hemu, a powerful general. Akbar's forces, under Bairam Khan's command, defeated Hemu and secured the Mughal throne.

Battle of Haldighati (1576):

Fought between Akbar's forces and Maharana Pratap of Mewar. Though Akbar's army, led by Man Singh, won the battle, Maharana Pratap continued his resistance.

Siege of Chittorgarh (1567-1568):

Akbar besieged and captured the fortress of Chittorgarh, a key Rajput stronghold, marking his expansion into Rajasthan.

Conquest of Gujarat And Bengal (1572-1576):

Akbar annexed Gujarat (1573) after defeating its ruler, Muzaffar Shah III. The victory gave him access to the western coast and trade routes. He annexed Bengal in 1576.

RELIGIOUS POLICY

- Akbar is best known for his policy of **religious tolerance.**
- He **abolished** the **"Jizya tax"** on non-Muslims, which was a major move towards building religious harmony.
- He encouraged interfaith dialogue among Muslims, Hindus, Christians, Jains, and others.
- He promoted the concept of **"Sulh-e-Kul" (Universal Peace)**, aimed at uniting people of all faiths under a single, tolerant empire.
- He founded the **"Din-i-Ilahi" (Divine Faith)**, a syncretic religion that blended elements of different religions, though it never gained many followers.

ADMINISTRATION

Revenue Administration

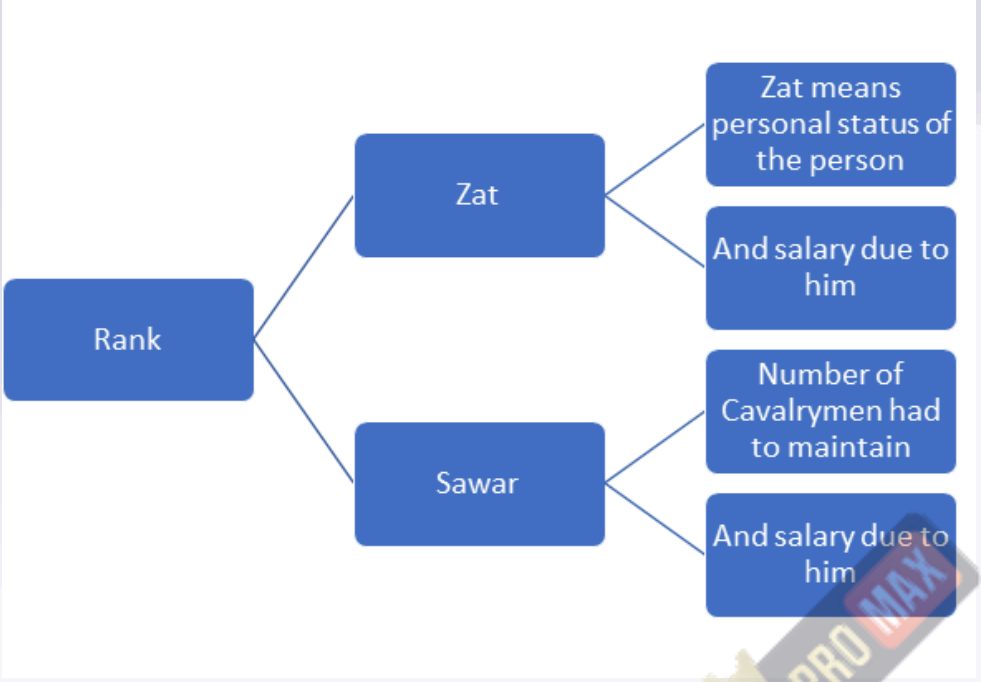
- **Annual Assessment Reverted**: Akbar replaced it with a more structured revenue system.
- **Karoris**: Officials appointed across North India to collect land revenue information and verify local officer reports.
- **Dashala System**: Based on average produce and prices over 10 years. One-third of the average produce was the state's share. This was not a 10-year or permanent settlement.
- **Zabti System**: Involved land measurement and assessment for revenue collection. Associated with Raja Todar Mal, it's also known as Todar Mal's Bandobast.
- **Batai/Ghalla-Bakshi System**: The state took a fixed proportion of the produce after harvesting. Peasants could choose between Zabti and Batai systems in certain conditions.
- Cash Crops: Cotton, indigo, oilseeds, and sugarcane were taxed in cash.
- **Nasdaq/Kunkut System**: Rough estimate of revenue based on past payments.

Classification of Lands

- Polaj Land - which remained under cultivation almost every year.
- Parati Land - it remained uncultivated. Parati land was paid at the full rate when it was cultivated.
- Chachar land - had been fallow for two or three years
- Banjar land - Had been fallow for more than three years

Mansabdari System

- Under this system, every officer was assigned a rank (Mansab).
- The lowest rank was 10, and the highest was 5000 for the nobles.
- Prices of the blood received higher Mansabs.
- However, the **origin of the Mansabdari system** can perhaps be traced back to **Changez Khan** who organized his army on a decimal basis.
- Towards the end of Akbar's reign, the highest rank a noble could attain was raised from 5000 to 7000.
- The ranks were divided into two: **Zat and Sawar.**



Army Reforms

- A descriptive roll **(Chehra)** of the soldier was maintained and his horse was branded with the imperial mark.
- This was called the **Dagh system**

Organization of Government

- The chief officers of the Sarkar were **Faujdar and Amalguzar.**
- The former being in charge of law and order and the latter is responsible for the assessment and collection of the land revenue.

AGRICULTURAL REFORMS

- Focused on improving and extending cultivation.
- Instructed Amils (officials) to support peasants like a father.
- Advanced loans (Taccavi) for seeds, tools, animals, etc., to be repaid in easy installments.
- **Jagir:**
  The land assignment is given instead of cash salary for revenue collection.
  Jagirdars collected revenue but had no control over the land itself.
- Similar to Iqtas in the Delhi Sultanate, with holders called Iqtadars.
- **Khalisa:**
  Lands where revenue went directly to the sultan's treasury.
  Khalisa referred to the type of land, not the type of revenue.

CENTRAL ADMINISTRATION

Wakil: Post given to important nobles; had little role in administration.

Wazir: Head of the revenue department.

Mir Bakshi: Head of the military department and the nobility.

Mir Saman: In charge of the royal household and provisions for the harem.

Qazi: Head of the judiciary.

AKBARNAMA

- The Akbarnama, meaning "Book of Akbar," is the official chronicle of the reign of Mughal Emperor Akbar, written by his court historian **Abul Fazl.**
- The Akbarnama is divided into **three main sections:**
- First Volume: Covers Akbar's ancestry, birth, and early life.
- Second Volume: Chronicles Akbar's reign, detailing political, military, and administrative events.
- Third Volume **(Ain-i-Akbari)**: Focuses on the administration, culture, and social structure of the Mughal Empire, including revenue systems, military organization, and court rituals.

ART AND ARCHITECTURE

Fusion of Styles:

Akbar's architecture combined Persian, Indian, and Central Asian styles, creating a unique Mughal style.

Fatehpur Sikri:

Akbar's most famous architectural project, this city is a blend of Islamic and Hindu elements. Key structures include Jama Masjid, Buland Darwaza, and Panch Mahal.

Red Fort of Agra:

Built with red sandstone, it showcases Mughal grandeur and served as Akbar's residence.

Tomb of Humayun:

Commissioned by Akbar, this structure greatly influenced later Mughal architecture, including the Taj Mahal.

Mughal Miniature Painting:

Akbar fostered the development of miniature painting. His court had famous painters like Basawan and Daswanth. This art form often depicted court scenes, battles, and nature.

Akbar’s Patronage:

Akbar encouraged the blending of Islamic art with local traditions, leading to a rich cultural legacy in both painting and architecture.